

Welcome to Magpie

Magpie helps you get organised with the files already on your computer — photos, videos, scans, PDFs, whatever you keep. You create a **project** (a single file on disk), point it at some folders, and Magpie shows you every file inside. From there you can:

- Give a file a **name**, **rename** it, and add **tags** — short labels like `beach`, `Christmas`, or `contract` — so you can find groups of files in seconds later on.
- Double-click any picture to open the **magnifier** and page through the rest with the arrow keys.
- Look at everything the file already knows about itself — resolution, camera, when it was taken, page count for PDFs — right next to the file.
- Delete the ones you don't want any more.

Everything stays on your computer. Nothing is uploaded, no account is needed, and you can keep using Magpie with no internet connection.

Why use Magpie?

Most people end up with files scattered across folders like `Camera Roll`, `iPhone Backup 2019`, and `Family - Copy (2)`. Windows gives you those folders and not much more. Magpie gives you a proper way to sort through them:

- **Find things fast.** Type `beach` in the search box and every file you tagged with `beach` shows up, no matter which folder it's in.
- **Nothing gets moved or modified inside the folders you add.** Your files stay exactly where they are on disk, byte-for-byte unchanged (unless you explicitly rename one). Tags and titles are saved inside your **project file**, which you choose the location of.
- **Multiple projects.** Keep one project for family photos and another for work receipts — they live in separate files and you can switch between them from the Project menu.
- **One tool for all your files.** Photos, videos, and documents all live in the same project, side by side, with the same tag search.

A quick tour, in under two minutes

1. **Create a project** the first time you launch (or open an existing one from **Project** → **Open Project...**).

2. **Click “+ Add folder”** at the top of the window and pick a folder full of files. Magpie gets to work reading everything it finds.
3. **Scroll** through the files in the big central area — it stays smooth even with tens of thousands.
4. **Double-click** any picture to open the magnifier; use ← / → to flip through neighbours and Esc to close.
5. **Click a file** to open the details panel on the right. Type a title. Add a tag. Rename the file. Everything saves as you go — there’s no “Save” button to remember.
6. **Hold Ctrl while clicking** to pick several files at once, then add the same tag to all of them.
7. **Tick tags in the left sidebar** to combine them with AND logic, or type in the search box to find files by title / filename.

That’s the whole app in a nutshell. The rest of this manual explains each part in a bit more detail.

What Magpie is *not*

- **Not an editor.** It won’t crop, straighten, retouch, or convert your files. Use another app for that.
- **Not a backup service.** Your files stay on your computer. If your hard drive fails, Magpie can’t help — copy your files somewhere safe (an external drive, OneDrive, etc.).
- **Not a face-recogniser.** It won’t guess who’s in your photos or auto-tag them.

If you want any of those, Magpie is happy to sit next to whichever tool does them for you — it won’t get in the way.

Installing and launching Magpie

What you need

- A PC running **Windows 10** or **Windows 11**.
- About **50 MB of free space** for the app.
- A little extra space for small thumbnail images (roughly 100 MB for every 10,000 files).

That's it. No account, no internet connection, no subscription.

Installing

Depending on where you got Magpie from, you'll have one of these:

- **An installer** (a file ending in `.msi` or `.exe`). Double-click it and follow the prompts. When Windows asks whether to allow the installer to make changes, click **Yes**.
- **A portable version** (just `desktop.exe`). Copy it wherever you like — for example, `C:\Programs\Magpie\` — and double-click it to launch. No installation needed.

If Windows shows a blue “Windows protected your PC” screen, click **More info** and then **Run anyway**. This happens with any small app that hasn't paid Microsoft for a code signature — it doesn't mean anything is wrong.

The very first time you open it

When you first start Magpie you'll see a friendly welcome screen with two buttons in the middle of the window:

- **New Project...** — creates a fresh empty project. You pick where to save it and what to call it (e.g. `Documents\Family.magpie`).
- **Open Project...** — opens an existing `.magpie` file.

Pick **New Project**, save it somewhere sensible, and Magpie opens into its normal three-panel layout. From then on, that project re-opens automatically every time you launch. See [Projects](#) for more.

Once the project is open the next step is to [add a folder](#) full of files to scan.

What Magpie creates on your computer

Magpie keeps a small workshop of its own in a hidden Windows folder:

```
C:\Users\<you>\AppData\Roaming\com.magpie.app\
```

That folder contains Magpie's preferences (`app-settings.json` , which remembers your recent projects and theme choices) and small thumbnail previews. **None of your original files live there** — they stay exactly where you put them — and your **project files live wherever you saved them**.

Uninstalling

- Installed with an `.msi` ? Open **Settings › Apps › Installed apps**, find Magpie, and click **Uninstall**.
- Portable version? Just delete `desktop.exe` .

To also wipe Magpie's cache and preferences, delete the hidden folder above (in File Explorer, paste `%APPDATA%\com.magpie.app` into the address bar). **Your project files aren't in there** unless you chose that location for them — they stay wherever you saved them.

Projects: creating, opening, switching

Everything Magpie remembers — your titles, tags, folder list, and smart collections — lives in one **project file** on disk. A project is just a single file with the `.magpie` extension. You choose where it lives (your Documents folder, an external drive, wherever) and what to call it (`FamilyPhotos.magpie`, `Work-Receipts.magpie`, ...).

Magpie can only have one project open at a time, so switching projects is like closing one photo album and opening another.

Your very first project

The first time you launch Magpie you'll see two buttons in the middle of the window:

- **New Project...** — create a brand-new empty project.
- **Open Project...** — open a `.magpie` file that already exists.

Pick **New Project**, choose where to save it (for example `Documents\Photos\Family.magpie`), and Magpie is ready. From then on that same project re-opens automatically every time you launch Magpie.

Upgrading from an earlier version? If Magpie already had data from before projects existed, that data is preserved as `Default.magpie` inside your Windows AppData folder and listed under **Recent projects** on the welcome screen the first time you launch the new version. Magpie won't open it for you — click it once and then, if you like, use **Project** → **Save Project As...** to move it somewhere you'll remember.

Opening a project by double-clicking

`.magpie` files show the Magpie icon in Windows Explorer, and double-clicking one opens it directly in Magpie. If Magpie is already running with a different project open, that instance switches to the one you double-clicked.

The Project menu

Everything project-related is in the **Project** menu on the menu bar:

Menu item	What it does
New Project...	Pick a location for a fresh empty project.
Open Project...	Open a project file that already exists.
Save Project	(Nothing to do — Magpie saves as you type.)
Save Project As...	Copy the current project to a new file and switch to it.
Close Project	Close the current project. Magpie returns to the welcome screen.
Exit	Quit the app.

The last-used project reopens on the next launch, provided you had a project open when you quit. If you'd rather have Magpie start on the welcome screen, close the project (Project → Close Project) before quitting.

Recent projects

The welcome screen shows the most recent projects you've opened, in order. Click one to open it — no dialog needed.

Multiple projects: when to use them

Keep everything in one project unless you have a strong reason to split. Some good reasons:

- **Different audiences.** A “personal photos” project on your laptop and a separate “wedding shoot” project on a work drive.
- **Different lifespans.** Long-lived family photos in one place; a short-term project (e.g. renovation documentation) in another that you'll archive when done.
- **Different backup strategies.** Store one project on a synced cloud folder and another on a local-only drive.

Since projects are just files, you can back one up by copying the `.magpie` file somewhere safe, share it by emailing the file, or archive it by moving it into a `.zip`.

Where the file actually is

Wherever you put it. If you forgot, the current project's location is shown in the top bar next to the project name; hover over it to see the full path. **Project** → **Save Project As...** copies it wherever you like.

Adding your first folder

Magpie needs to know which folders on your computer contain the files you want to organise. Once you tell it, it does the rest.

Add a folder in three clicks

1. Click **+ Add folder** at the top of the window.
2. In the dialog that opens, browse to the folder that has your files — for example `C:\Users\me\Pictures\Vacation 2024`.
3. Click **Select folder**.

That's it. Magpie starts looking through the folder right away. The bar at the bottom of the window shows what's happening ("Reading 234 of 1,205 files...") and updates as it goes.

You don't have to wait for it to finish — files appear in the window as they're found, so you can start browsing (and even tagging) straight away.

What Magpie does when you add a folder

Behind the scenes, Magpie:

- **Looks in the folder and every folder inside it.** So adding `Pictures` also picks up `Pictures\2020`, `Pictures\Kids`, and so on. Video and document files are picked up too — see [Supported file formats](#).
- **Reads the built-in info** each file exposes: dimensions, camera, duration, page count, and so on.
- **Reads any tags or titles** already saved with the file (for example, tags you added earlier in Windows Explorer).
- **Makes small thumbnail previews** for images so the grid loads instantly, even for very large libraries.

Your original files are **not moved, renamed, or changed** in any way during this. Magpie only reads them.

If you turned on [Auto-tag photos](#) in Settings, Magpie also runs its built-in tagger on each photo right after the scan finishes. You'll see a second green **Auto-tagging** progress bar in the

status bar at the bottom of the window. The suggested tags land in each photo's **Automatic tags** section (read-only) so it's obvious a machine picked them. This step is off by default.

Adding more folders

You can add as many folders as you like — one for your holidays, one for family, one for work documents, whatever suits you.

Every folder you add appears under **Library › Folders** in the left-hand sidebar. Click a folder name there to see only the files inside that folder.

Removing a folder

Right-click the folder name in the sidebar and choose **Remove from library**. Magpie forgets about it — but **your files stay on your computer**. Removing a folder from Magpie is not the same as deleting it from your PC.

Refreshing when files change

If you drop new files into a folder using File Explorer, or edit some in another app, Magpie doesn't know about it right away. To catch up:

- **Right-click a folder name** in the sidebar and choose **Rescan folder**, or
- Click **Rescan** at the top of the window to check every folder at once.

Rescanning is quick — Magpie only looks at files that have changed since the last time it checked.

Browsing your library

The big area in the middle of the window is your **file grid**. It shows every file Magpie knows about, all in one long scrollable page. Even with tens of thousands of files, it stays smooth to scroll.

Picking files

- **Click a file** to select it. It gets a blue outline, and its details appear in the panel on the right.
- **Ctrl + click** more files to add them to the selection.
- **Shift + click** somewhere else in the grid to grab everything between the first and the new click.
- **Double-click** a file to open the [Magnifier](#) — a full-window viewer for browsing pictures one by one.
- **Esc** unpicks everything.

The number of selected files is shown in the panel on the right and in the status bar at the bottom.

Sorting the grid

There's a **Sort** menu in the top bar. Choose what makes sense for the moment:

- **Taken** — when the file was taken/created (from the file itself). Great for going through a trip in order.
- **Filename** — A to Z by name.
- **Added** — the day the file was added to your library.
- **Size** — largest or smallest first.

The little arrow next to the sort menu flips between ascending and descending.

The details panel on the right

Click a file and its details appear on the right, split into four sections:

1. **Title** — a short, editable name.
2. **Tags** — labels you add for grouping and searching.
3. **Format metadata** — which handler Magpie is using and whether it can save your edits into the file itself.
4. **File info** — read-only technical information (size, resolution, camera, duration, page count...). What appears here depends on the file type.

Editing any of the top two sections saves automatically — no Save button. The next chapter, [Editing metadata](#), goes into detail.

If you pick more than one file at once, the details panel switches into a batch mode — see [Working on many files at once](#).

The sidebar filters

The list on the left is a set of filters — clicking (or ticking) narrows down the grid to matching files.

- **Library › Folders**: show only files from one specific folder on your computer.
- **Tags: click a tag bubble** to add it to the search. Click several bubbles to narrow with AND logic (a file has to have every selected tag to appear). The tiny number inside each bubble is how many files carry that tag. Click **Clear all** in the Tags header to deselect every bubble in one go.

Filters stack. Click a folder **and** select some tag bubbles **and** type text in the search box — Magpie shows the intersection.

Clearing filters

Click **All photos** at the top of the sidebar to reset the folder filter. Use **Clear all** in the Tags header to un-tick every tag. Clear the search box to drop any typed-text filter.

The Magnifier

The Magnifier is a **separate pop-up window** that shows the current picture at full size. It runs alongside the main Magpie window, so you can keep browsing the grid while the Magnifier stays open on a second monitor (or dragged out of the way on a single monitor).

Opening it

- **Double-click** any tile in the grid — the fastest path.
- Select a tile and choose **View** → **Magnifier** (or press F11).
- If the details panel is showing a preview, **double-click that preview**.

If you trigger the Magnifier again while the pop-up is already open, it jumps to the newly-chosen picture in the existing window instead of opening a second one.

View → **Magnifier** is greyed out until you select a file — there has to be something to magnify.

Using it

Do this	And...
← / ↑	Show the previous file in the current filter.
→ / ↓	Show the next file in the current filter.
Esc	Close the Magnifier window.
Click “Close”	Same as Esc.

Along the bottom of the pop-up you’ll see the file’s title (or its filename if there’s no title), your position in the list (for example, “34 / 128”), and prev / next / close buttons. The window title updates to the current filename as you navigate.

Which files can I flip through?

Whatever was visible in the grid **at the moment you opened the Magnifier** — Magpie walks through the same list, in the same order, using your current sort. If you have tag chips or free-text search active, the arrows stay within that filtered subset. Changing the filter in the main window afterwards doesn't reshuffle the Magnifier; close and re-open it to pick up the new list.

Non-image files

The Magnifier only knows how to display picture formats your PC can draw (JPEG, PNG, WEBP, GIF, BMP, TIFF). For a PDF or video the Magnifier will show a “no image to display” message — open those files in their own app instead.

Searching and filtering

Once you've added tags and titles to a good number of files, finding them again is a treat. Magpie combines two kinds of filter — **tag chips** you pick from the sidebar and **free-text search** you type in the box — and the grid updates as you go.

Search + tag chips: how they combine

The search box at the top of the window is really two things:

- **Chips** on the left, one per tag you've ticked in the sidebar. Every chip narrows the grid with **AND** logic — a file has to have *all* the ticked tags to appear.
- **Free text** on the right, which matches the file's title, filename, or any of its tags.

You can mix them freely. For example: tick `beach` and `2023` in the sidebar (two chips appear), then type `family` in the box, and the grid shows every file tagged both `beach` **and** `2023` whose title, filename, or tag also matches `family`.

Ticking, un-ticking, and clearing tags

- **Tick a tag** in the sidebar to add its chip to the search box.
- **Untick** it, or click the chip's × in the search box, to remove it from the search.
- **Clear all** in the sidebar's Tags header un-ticks every tag in one click.
- **Backspace** in the empty search box removes the rightmost chip.

What the free-text search matches

The typed text is matched against three places on every file:

- The **title** you gave it.
- The **tags** attached to it.
- The **filename** (like `IMG_4523.jpg` or `contract_signed.pdf`).

Capital letters don't matter: `Beach` and `beach` find the same files.

Handy search tricks (typed text)

- `beach vacation` — finds files with **both** words somewhere.
- `beach OR mountain` — finds files with **either** word.
- `vacation -beach` — vacation files that are **not** tagged beach.
- `"family reunion"` — the exact phrase, in that order.

Prefix matching is on for the last word — `sun` matches `sunset`, `sunny`, `sunbathing`.

Combining with folders

Clicking a folder in the sidebar narrows the grid to files inside that folder. It works together with tags and search — click a folder, tick some tags, type some text, and you get the intersection of all three.

Click **All photos** at the top of the sidebar to remove the folder filter without losing your tag chips.

Nothing found?

If a search turns up empty and you were expecting results:

- Check for a typo. `caht` won't find `cat` files.
- Try a shorter word. `mount` finds both `mountain` and `mountains`.
- Look at the tag chips — if you have several ticked, you're asking Magpie for files matching **all** of them. Untick one at a time or use **Clear all** to widen the search.

Editing metadata

Metadata is a fancy word for “information about a file” — its title, tags, and filename. It’s what makes a folder of `IMG_1234.jpg` and `document_final_v3.pdf` files feel like a real library.

To edit any of this, click one file in the grid. The **details panel** on the right lights up with everything you can change.

What the panel shows

The details panel is split into sections, top to bottom:

1. **Title** — a short, editable name (e.g. “Anna’s birthday cake”).
2. **Your tags**  — little labels **you** add inside Magpie: `beach`, `family`, `2024`, `contract`. Fully editable. A tiny pencil next to the section header shows it’s the editable one.
3. **Automatic tags**  — labels Magpie found **already stored in the file itself** when it scanned the folder (for example, tags you set in Windows Explorer, Adobe Lightroom, or Bridge), plus anything Magpie’s built-in auto-tagger contributed if you turned it on. This section is **always shown** — with a small lock icon in the header and each pill — so the distinction stays visible on every file. It’s **read-only** here: no × on the pills, no way to type into the box. See [Automatic vs. your tags](#) below for how to change them.
4. **Format metadata** — the name of the file’s format handler (JPEG, PNG, PDF, MP4, ...). This will grow as Magpie learns to edit more format-specific properties.
5. **File info** — everything Magpie learned from the file itself: size, resolution, when it was taken, camera used, page count, video duration, and so on. Most of it is read-only; **the filename row is editable** — see below.

Everything saves as you type

There is **no Save button**. Magpie saves your changes automatically:

- **Title**: saved a moment after you stop typing (or as soon as you click somewhere else).
- **Tags**: saved immediately once you press space, Enter or comma.
- **Filename**: saved when you press **Enter**; **Esc** or clicking away reverts to the previous value.

You’ll see a tiny “Saving...” note when it’s happening. It usually takes less than half a second.

Setting a title

Click the **Title** box, type a name, click somewhere else (or wait a moment). Done.

To clear a title, just erase what's there.

Renaming the file

Under **File info**, the **Filename** row is a text field. Edit it however you like and press **Enter** — Magpie renames the file on disk **and** updates its record in the project in one step. If the new name would collide with another file in the same folder, or contains characters Windows won't allow (\ / : * ? " < > |), the rename is refused and the field turns back to the old name.

Esc or clicking away without pressing Enter throws your edit away.

Just changed a filename you shouldn't have? Use **Edit** → **Undo** (Ctrl + Z) — Magpie will rename the file back for you.

Adding tags

Click the **Your tags** box. Type a word — for example `family` — and then press one of:

- **Space**
- **Enter**
- **Comma**

The tag becomes a little pill you can see. Type another word, press space, and there's another. Keep going for as many tags as you want.

While you type, Magpie suggests tags you've already used elsewhere, so you don't end up with `Beach`, `beach`, and `beaches` all meaning the same thing. Use the arrow keys to pick a suggestion and press Enter.

To **remove a tag**, hover over its pill and click the little ✕. This only removes it from **Your tags**. If the same word also shows up under **Automatic tags**, it stays there and the file still shows up in searches for that tag.

Automatic vs. your tags

Magpie splits tags into two kinds and shows both, in their own section, on every file:

- **Your tags** ✎ — anything you typed in Magpie’s details panel. Editable at any time.
- **Automatic tags** 🔒 — anything the file **already had** when Magpie first scanned it: keywords added in Windows Explorer’s Properties → Details, tags from Adobe Lightroom or Bridge, or entries in a Lightroom `.xmp` sidecar next to the file. This section is **disabled for editing**: you can read the tags, hover them, and search on them, but there’s no × on the pills and no input box. The container has a dashed outline and each pill carries a small lock icon so it’s obvious at a glance that it’s read-only. If the file has no such tags the section still shows, with a “No automatic tags on this file.” note, so the distinction is never hidden. **To change or remove an automatic tag, edit the file in the original tool and rescan the folder** — Magpie will then pick up whatever the file says.

Both kinds count together when you search or when you look at the sidebar bubbles: a file tagged `beach` shows up whether the tag came from you or from the file itself, and Magpie doesn’t double-count if the same word is present in both categories.

Rescanning a folder never wipes your typed tags. If a file’s own metadata changes between scans, Magpie will pick up any new automatic tags but leaves your entries alone.

Every file is taggable

You can tag anything Magpie recognises — JPEG, PNG, RAW, HEIC, MP4, PDF, everything. There is no “this file type can’t be tagged” warning, because tags never touch the source file: they live in your project file (see [Where your data lives](#)).

Undo / Redo

Edit → **Undo** (Ctrl + Z) reverses your most recent title change, tag change, or rename. **Edit** → **Redo** (Ctrl + Y) reapplies it. The history is per session — it clears when you close the project or quit the app.

If a save fails

If a save fails, a red note appears under the field explaining what went wrong. The usual culprits:

- **Disk full** — free up space.
- **File is locked** by another program (a rename can fail because Photoshop or a preview window has the file open). Close the other app and try again.
- **Project file can't be written** — very rare; usually a permissions issue on the drive that holds your `.magpie` file.

Working on many files at once

Editing files one at a time is fine when there are only a few. But when you have hundreds — say, an entire holiday — you'll want to tag them all in one go. Magpie is built for exactly that.

Picking several files

- **Click** the first file.
- **Ctrl + click** each of the other files you want to include.
- Or **Shift + click** at the far end to grab everything in between.
- **Ctrl + A** grabs every file in the current view.

The details panel on the right immediately switches to a batch view that reads *"N files selected"*. The number ticks up as you add more.

Adding tags to all of them

Batch mode shows two tag boxes:

- **Add tags** — anything you put here gets added to every selected file. Files that already had the tag are simply left alone.
- **Remove tags** — anything you put here gets removed from every selected file.

You can queue up multiple tags before hitting the button. When you're ready, click **Apply tag changes to N files**. A confirmation appears when it's done: *"Updated N files."*

Tip. Add tags in bulk first, then use the sidebar to check your work. Click the tag on the left — the grid narrows to just the files that have it, and you can see whether everything landed correctly.

Deleting them all at once

At the bottom of the details panel there's a red **Delete N files** button. Click it, confirm the prompt, and the whole selection heads to the Recycle Bin. See [Deleting files](#) for the full story.

What if one file won't accept a change?

Two cases where a file gets skipped:

1. **The folder is read-only** (an old backup drive, or something you pulled off a DVD). Fix the permissions on that folder (right-click → *Properties* in File Explorer) and try again.
2. **The file's format doesn't support embedded tags yet** (RAW, HEIC, PDF, video...). Magpie still remembers the tag in its own library, but it can't write it back into the file. The rest of the batch gets updated normally.

Either way, Magpie shows a message at the end telling you which files were skipped and why.

Tags: adding, renaming, cleaning up

Tags are little labels you stick on files so you can find them later. There are no folders-inside-folders or complicated structures — tags are just words. A file can have as many as you want.

Good tags are things you'd naturally think of later:

- **Places:** Iceland, beach, home.
- **People:** Emma, Grandad, the twins.
- **Events:** wedding, Christmas-2024, hike.
- **Feelings:** favourites, funny, to-print.

Two kinds of tags

Magpie shows tags in **two categories** for every file:

- **Your tags** — words you typed yourself in Magpie. Editable any time.
- **Automatic tags** — words the file **already had** when Magpie first saw it: keywords from Windows Explorer's Properties dialog, from Adobe Lightroom, from a `.xmp` sidecar next to the file, and so on. When you have [Auto-tag photos](#) turned on, Magpie's built-in tagger's suggestions **also land here**, next to those, so every read-only, machine-picked tag lives in one place. Shown in the details panel as a read-only row (with a lock icon) so you can see and search on what the file says — but you can't remove them one at a time from Magpie. To change them, edit the file in the tool that wrote them and rescan (for XMP / Explorer keywords), or turn Auto-tag off and use the sidebar's right-click **Delete tag** to sweep an unwanted AI name away everywhere.

Everywhere else — sidebar bubbles, searches, the top-of-window search box — Magpie treats both kinds as one. A file tagged `beach` appears whether the tag came from you or from the file, and if the same word is in both categories it isn't counted twice.

See [Editing metadata → Automatic vs. your tags](#) for the full story.

Adding tags

The most detailed walkthrough is in [Editing metadata](#). In short:

- Click the **Your tags** box in the details panel.

- Type a word.
- Press **Space**, **Enter**, or **Comma** to save it.

Repeat as many times as you like. To **remove** a tag, click the little ✕ on its pill. Only **Your tags** can be removed like this; automatic tags don't have an ✕ because they live in the file itself.

Capital letters don't matter — `Beach` and `beach` are treated as the same tag.

The tag cloud in the sidebar

Every tag you've ever used appears as a **bubble** in the **Tags** section of the sidebar on the left. Bubbles flow across as many rows as they need. Each bubble carries the tag name and a small number — how many files carry that tag.

- **Click a bubble** to add that tag to the current search. It turns filled in the accent colour so it's easy to spot.
- Click **several** bubbles to narrow with AND logic (files must carry *every* selected tag to appear).
- **Click a filled bubble** again to drop it from the search.
- **Clear all** in the Tags header deselects every bubble in one click.
- **Right-click a bubble** for two options: **Rename** and **Delete**.

Selected tags also appear as removable chips in the search box at the top of the window — clicking the ✕ on a chip deselects it here.

Renaming a tag

Made a typo? Change your mind on capitalisation? Right-click the tag and choose **Rename tag...** Type the new name and confirm.

Magpie updates the tag on **every file that had it**, all at once. There's no per-file work to do.

Deleting a tag

Right-click the tag → **Delete tag**. This removes the tag from every file — but it does not delete any files. Only the label goes.

Autocompletion — save yourself typos

While you type a new tag, Magpie shows a small dropdown of tags you've used before that start with the same letters. Use the arrow keys to pick one and press Enter. This is the easiest way to keep your tag list tidy — no more `beach`, `beaches`, `beach`, `beach-day`.

Tips for tagging a big library

- **Start broad.** Tag by place or year first — `Iceland`, `2024`. Once every file has broad tags, narrow ones (`glacier`, `Reykjavik`) are easier because you can filter down first.
- **Use multi-select.** `Ctrl + click` many files and add tags to them all in one go.
- **Don't over-tag.** A tag that's on 8,000 files isn't very useful. When in doubt, pick tags that would show fewer than a few hundred results.

Do tags show up in other apps?

Only the automatic ones.

- **Your tags** live inside your **project file** (the `.magpie` file you chose the location of). Magpie does not write them into the source files, so Windows Explorer, Adobe Lightroom, etc. won't see them.
- **Automatic tags** were already stored inside the file by whichever tool put them there, so they're still visible in that tool.

The upside is that Magpie **doesn't modify your files** and every file type is fully taggable inside Magpie. The downside is that if you want tags to travel with the file (email a JPEG to a friend and keep its tag visible in their photo viewer), you need to tag it in Explorer or Bridge instead — Magpie will then pick that tag up as an **automatic** tag on its next scan. See [Interoperability with other tools](#) for the details.

Supported file formats

Magpie can put every file below into your library and let you tag and search it. **Every recognised file is fully taggable** — the tags just don't go into the file itself. They live in Magpie's own database in your Windows AppData folder; see [Where your data lives](#) for the details.

That means: **if Magpie shows the file in the grid, you can tag it.** No more “sorry, this format has no writable property handler” warning.

Images

- **JPEG** — .jpg, .jpeg, .jpe, .jfif
- **PNG** — .png
- **WebP** — .webp
- **GIF** — .gif
- **TIFF** — .tif, .tiff
- **HEIF family** — .heic, .heif, .hif, .avif
- **JPEG XL / JPEG XR / HD Photo** — .jxl, .jxr, .wdp
- **Older raster formats** — .bmp, .dib, .exr, .hdr, .hdp
- **JPEG 2000 family** — .jp2, .j2k, .j2c, .jpx, .jif
- **Vector** — .svg
- **Photoshop** — .psd, .psb

Camera RAW

- **Canon** — .cr2, .cr3, .crw
- **Nikon** — .nef, .nrw
- **Sony** — .arw, .sr2, .srf, .arq
- **Fuji** — .raf
- **Olympus** — .orf, .ori
- **Panasonic** — .rw2, .rw1
- **Pentax** — .pef
- **Samsung** — .srw
- **Sigma** — .x3f
- **Adobe / generic** — .dng

Video

- **MP4 family** — `.mp4`, `.m4v`, `.mov`, `.3gp`, `.3gpp`, `.3g2`
- **Legacy Windows** — `.wmv`, `.asf`
- **MPEG transport / Matroska / AVI** — `.ts`, `.mts`, `.m2ts`, `.mkv`, `.mks`, `.mka`, `.webm`, `.avi`, `.qt`

Documents

- **PDF** — `.pdf`

Existing tags in your files

If a JPEG (or any format above) already carries XMP tags from Adobe Bridge / Lightroom, or the Explorer *Properties* → *Details* dialog, Magpie **reads them once** on the first scan and imports them into the folder's database. From that point on you can edit the tags in Magpie freely — but Magpie will never write into the source file again. See [Interoperability with other tools](#).

Files Magpie ignores

Anything not in the tables above is skipped when you scan a folder. That's intentional — a system file or ZIP archive doesn't usually belong in a photo/video library.

If you want a new file type supported, that's a normal thing to ask for. The Magpie backend has a small “format handler” plug-in system so new types can be added without touching the rest of the app.

Deleting files

Sooner or later you'll want to get rid of some files — blurry shots, duplicates, an old draft PDF, that photo of a light switch from someone's pocket. Magpie deletes them safely, with a confirmation, and puts them in the **Recycle Bin** so you can undo the deletion if you change your mind.

Deleting one file

1. Click the file in the grid.
2. Either:
 - Click the red **Delete file** button at the bottom of the details panel, **or**
 - Press the **Delete** key on your keyboard.
3. A prompt asks: *"Move IMG_2043.jpg to the Recycle Bin?"*.
4. Click **Move to Recycle Bin** to confirm — or **Cancel** to back out.

The file disappears from Magpie and lands in the Windows Recycle Bin.

Deleting many files at once

1. Pick lots of files with **Ctrl + click** or **Shift + click**.
2. Click **Delete N files** at the bottom of the details panel (or press the **Delete** key).
3. Confirm the prompt.

What actually happens when you delete

- The file is moved to the **Windows Recycle Bin** — the same Recycle Bin you already know.
- Any tags Magpie had for that file go with it.
- Any leftover `.xmp` sidecar next to the file is deleted too.
- Magpie forgets the file (until you restore it — see below).

Nothing is deleted permanently — unless you tell it to (see the next section).

Getting a file back after deleting

Made a mistake? No problem:

1. Double-click the **Recycle Bin** on your desktop.
2. Find your file.
3. Right-click it → **Restore**.

The file goes back exactly where it was. The next time you click **Rescan** in Magpie, it re-appears in the library with its tags and title still on it.

Permanently deleting (no safety net)

If you're absolutely sure a file is gone-for-good, hold the **Shift** key while pressing Delete (or while clicking the delete button). The prompt will say *"Permanently delete"* instead of *"Move to Recycle Bin"*.

Warning. Permanent deletion cannot be undone. Do not use it unless you're 100% sure — and always keep a backup of important files.

If in doubt, use the normal delete. You can always empty the Recycle Bin later.

What is *not* deleted

- **Removing a folder from Magpie is not deleting.** The files stay on your computer.
- **Un-tagging is not deleting.** Removing every tag from a file just leaves it un-tagged.
- **A tag that no file uses any more** doesn't get deleted automatically. You can right-click it in the sidebar and choose **Delete tag** to clean it up.

The menu bar

Across the top of the window is a standard menu bar with four menus: **Project**, **Edit**, **View**, and **Settings**. This chapter lists what each item does.

Project

Everything about the current project file — see [Projects](#) for the full walkthrough.

Item	Shortcut	What it does
New Project...	Ctrl + N	Create a new project.
Open Project...	Ctrl + O	Open an existing project.
Save Project	Ctrl + S	(Nothing to do — Magpie saves as you type.)
Save Project As...	Ctrl + Shift + S	Copy the current project to a new file.
Close Project		Close the current project.
Exit	Alt + F4	Quit Magpie.

Edit

The **Edit** menu covers session-only undo / redo for the changes you make with the details panel. Both items are greyed out until you've actually made a change (or, for Redo, until you've undone one).

Item	Shortcut	What it undoes
Undo	Ctrl + Z	The last title change, tag change, or filename rename.
Redo	Ctrl + Y	Reapplies whatever you just undid.

Undo history is **per session** — it's cleared when you close the project or quit the app.

View

Item	Shortcut	What it does
Magnifier	F11	Opens the currently-selected picture full-window. Use ← / → to walk through the grid, Esc to close. Double-clicking a tile in the grid does the same thing.

Settings

Item	What it does
Language...	Currently English-only. (Additional languages are on the roadmap.)
Theme...	Choose Dark, Light, or Follow-system. Your choice is remembered.
Font size...	Small, Medium (default), or Large — scales the whole UI.
Auto-tag photos	Toggle Magpie's built-in tagger. A trailing ✓ means it's on. See Settings → Auto-tag photos .

All settings apply immediately and are saved in `%APPDATA%\com.magpie.app\app-settings.json`.

Settings

Open **Settings** on the menu bar to choose your theme, font size, and language. Each choice is stored on your PC and applies immediately — no restart needed.

Theme

- **Follow system** (default) — matches whichever mode Windows is running.
- **Dark** — always the classic dark UI.
- **Light (preview)** — a lighter palette. This is a preview; some spots may still look off and we're polishing them.

Font size

Pick **Small**, **Medium** (the default), or **Large** to scale labels, filenames, and metadata. If you're on a high-DPI screen and find text tiny, **Large** is the friend you're looking for.

Language

Magpie currently ships in English only. This dialog will grow as we add more languages.

Auto-tag photos

When this is on, Magpie automatically suggests a couple of tags for every photo in a folder as soon as you add that folder to a project. The suggestions land in the photo's **Automatic tags** list — the same read-only section where tags read from the file itself live — so they are clearly marked as machine-picked and can't be removed one at a time from Magpie. To sweep an unwanted AI tag off every photo at once, right-click it in the sidebar and pick **Delete tag**.

- **Off by default.** Nothing runs unless you turn it on.
- Toggle it from **Settings** → **Auto-tag photos** on the menu bar. A checkmark (✓) at the end of the label means it's on.
- The work happens on your PC — no photo ever leaves your machine.

- You'll see a green **Auto-tagging** progress bar in the status bar at the bottom of the window while it runs, next to the usual Scanning bar. Magpie stays fully responsive while it works.
- If you add several folders in a row, Magpie tags them one after the other so your PC doesn't grind to a halt.
- Adding the same folder again later, or rescanning, doesn't re-do photos that haven't changed since Magpie last tagged them.
- Only the initial add of a folder triggers auto-tagging. A plain rescan doesn't.

The first version ships with a simple built-in tagger that picks from a fixed short list of everyday tags (landscape, portrait, indoor, outdoor, day, night, nature, city, water, food, people, animal). It's a starting point — a smarter model can slot in later without changing anything you see.

If you decide auto-tag isn't for you, toggle it off. Tags that were already added stay put in **Automatic tags** on the affected photos. Because that section is read-only, you can't clean them up photo-by-photo from the details panel — instead right-click the name in the sidebar's tag cloud and pick **Delete tag** to remove it from every file at once.

Where these live

Your choices are written to:

```
C:\Users\<you>\AppData\Roaming\com.magpie.app\app-settings.json
```

The same file also remembers your most recently opened projects and which project should re-open on next launch. It never contains anything private — feel free to delete it to reset to defaults.

Where your data lives

A quick, plain-language tour of what Magpie puts where. You don't need to know any of this to use the app — but many people like knowing exactly where their information ends up.

Your files

Your files stay where you put them. Magpie never moves them, and never modifies their contents. The only thing Magpie can change on disk is a file's **name**, and only when you explicitly rename it in the details panel.

Magpie never writes tags into your files. Older versions of Magpie tried to embed tags directly into JPEGs and PNGs. That approach caused problems (files got modified even when the user was just browsing, some formats couldn't be written to at all, cloud sync services would re-upload gigabytes for a one-word tag change). Magpie now leaves file contents completely untouched.

Your tags and titles: the project file

Tags, titles, folder lists, and smart searches all live inside **your project file** — a single `.magpie` file you chose the location and name of. For example:

```
C:\Users\<you>\Documents\Family.magpie
```

That single file remembers:

- Every folder you've added to the project.
- Every image Magpie has seen in each folder.
- The tags and title you've set for each image.
- A search index so typing in the search box is instant.
- Any smart searches (saved searches) you've created.

Because it's just a file, you can:

- **Back it up** by copying it somewhere safe.
- **Share it** by emailing or moving it to another PC. On the other PC, open Magpie → **Project** → **Open Project...** and pick your copy.

- **Archive it** by moving it into a `.zip`.

Every file becomes taggable. RAW files, videos, PDFs, HEIC, TIFF, and every other format are all tagged the same way now, because the tags are in your project file, not in the file.

Multiple projects

You can have as many project files as you like — for example one for family photos and another for work documents. Magpie can only have **one open at a time**; switch between them from the **Project** menu. See [Projects](#).

Existing tags in your files

If your photos already carry XMP tags (from Lightroom, Bridge, or older versions of Magpie), or Windows Explorer keywords set through the *Properties* → *Details* tab, Magpie **reads them once** on the first scan and imports them into your project. From that point on the project file is the source of truth — later edits in Magpie stay in the project, and Magpie does **not** try to keep the file's embedded tags in sync.

If you also edit tags in Explorer or Lightroom, Magpie won't see those edits until you rescan the folder and manually reimport, so pick one tool as your master. See [Interoperability with other tools](#).

Folders on OneDrive, Dropbox, or a network share

You can point Magpie at any folder on any drive, including cloud-synced locations like OneDrive, Dropbox, Google Drive, iCloud Drive, or a network share. The project file can live wherever you want too — including a synced location if you want your tags to follow you between PCs.

Magpie's own workshop

Even though your project lives wherever you saved it, Magpie also keeps a small workshop of its own in a hidden Windows folder:

```
C:\Users\<you>\AppData\Roaming\com.magpie.app\
```

That folder has:

- **app-settings.json** — remembers which project was last open, your recent-projects list, and your theme / font-size / language choices.
- **Default.magpie** — only present if Magpie converted an older-format library into a project on your behalf. It's just a normal project file; move it wherever you like.
- Small **thumbnail images** so the grid loads without delay (`thumbs\` subfolder). Thumbnails are stored in a separate subdirectory for each project so switching between projects never shows you a preview from the wrong one.
- A **log file** that helps if you ever run into trouble (`logs\app.log`).

None of your projects have to live here — you're free to save them wherever you want.

The three golden rules

1. **Magpie never modifies file contents.** It never uploads them, and it can only rename them when you explicitly do so.
2. **Magpie never uploads anything.** No internet, no cloud, no account.
3. **All your tags and titles are in your project file.** Copy the `.magpie` file and you've copied everything Magpie knows about that project.

Backing up

Back up your `.magpie` file(s). That's your whole Magpie library in one file per project.

Your original photo folders don't need special backup treatment — they don't contain any Magpie data. Copying them elsewhere copies only the pixels, not the tags. If you move to a new PC and want your tags to come with you, copy the `.magpie` file(s) too.

Working with other tools

Magpie keeps your tags in its own database, not inside the files themselves. That has two implications for other tools:

- **The files themselves are never modified.** Every viewer and editor on your PC sees exactly the bytes the camera (or Photoshop, or Lightroom) originally produced.
- **Tags don't automatically sync between Magpie and Explorer / Lightroom.** If you want them to end up in the file, you'll need to write them out with the other tool as before — Magpie won't do that automatically.

Importing existing tags

If a photo already has tags in it (added earlier by Lightroom, Bridge, or the *Properties* → *Details* dialog in Explorer, or an older version of Magpie), Magpie **reads them once** on the first scan of that folder and imports them into its database.

- XMP `dc:subject`, Microsoft-Photo `MP:LastKeywordXMP`, and Windows Shell `System.Keywords` are all recognised.
- The imported title comes from XMP `dc:title` or `System.Title`.

After that first-scan import, Magpie treats its database as the truth. Later edits you make in Lightroom, Bridge, or Explorer will **not** show up in Magpie until you re-import the folder.

Refreshing after external edits

If you know a file was retagged outside Magpie and want to bring those tags back in, the simplest path is:

1. **Remove** the folder from Magpie (right-click it in the sidebar → *Remove from library*). Your files aren't touched.
2. **Add** the folder again. The first-scan import runs and picks up the current XMP / Explorer keywords for every file.

Anything you'd added *only* inside Magpie for that folder will be lost by this step, because Magpie doesn't write tags back into the files. Use it only when the external tool is the authoritative source.

In short

- Magpie doesn't fight other tools for control of your files.
- If Magpie is your primary tagging tool, everything just works.
- If your other tool is primary and you want its tags in Magpie, re-import that folder from time to time.

Keyboard shortcuts

You can do everything in Magpie with a mouse, but keyboard shortcuts make the whole thing much faster once you know them.

Projects

Shortcut	What it does
Ctrl + N	New Project...
Ctrl + O	Open Project...
Ctrl + S	Save Project (a no-op — Magpie auto-saves)
Ctrl + Shift + S	Save Project As...
Alt + F4	Quit Magpie

Editing

Shortcut	What it does
Ctrl + Z	Undo the last title / tag / rename change
Ctrl + Y	Redo

The Undo / Redo history is per session — it clears when you close the project or quit the app.

Magnifier

Shortcut	What it does
F11	Open the currently-selected file in the magnifier
Double-click	Same as F11 on the file you double-clicked

Shortcut	What it does
← / ↑	Previous file (inside the magnifier)
→ / ↓	Next file
Esc	Close the magnifier

Picking files

Shortcut	What it does
Click	Pick one file
Ctrl + Click	Add or remove one file from your selection
Shift + Click	Pick everything between the last click and this one
Esc	Unpick everything

Everyday actions

Shortcut	What it does
Delete	Send the selected files to the Recycle Bin
Backspace (empty search)	Remove the rightmost tag chip

Titles and tags

Shortcut	What it does
Enter (in the title)	Save what you typed
Enter (in the filename)	Rename the file on disk
Esc (in the filename)	Revert to the previous filename
Enter (in the tag box)	Save the tag you just typed

Shortcut	What it does
Space (in the tag box)	Save the tag you just typed
Comma (in the tag box)	Save the tag you just typed
Backspace (empty tag box)	Remove the last tag you added

Troubleshooting

Most bumps you'll hit fall into one of the buckets below. If none of these matches your problem, Magpie keeps a diary in a log file that can help — the last section explains where to find it.

The app won't open

What happens: You double-click Magpie and either nothing happens or you get a “WebView2” error message.

Fix: Install the free **Microsoft Edge WebView2 Runtime** from Microsoft's website. It's a small download. Windows 11 already has it; Windows 10 usually gets it automatically through Windows Update.

Tags I added in File Explorer don't show up in Magpie

What happens: You right-click a file in File Explorer, add a tag under **Properties › Details**, but Magpie doesn't list it.

Why: Magpie's tag data lives in its own database, not inside the file. Explorer edits go into the file. Magpie reads those file tags **once**, on first scan of the folder, and then treats its database as the source of truth.

Fix: Right-click the folder in the sidebar and choose **Remove from library**, then add the folder again. The first scan re-imports whatever tags Explorer, Bridge, or Lightroom have put in the files. Any tags you'd already added in Magpie for that folder are lost by this step, so use it only when the other tool is the authoritative tagger.

Tags I added in Magpie don't show up in File Explorer

What happens: You add a tag in Magpie, open the file's properties in File Explorer, and the Tags row is empty.

Why: Magpie doesn't write into your files. Tags live only in Magpie's database.

If you need the tag inside the file (for example so it survives being sent to a friend by email), tag the file with Explorer's *Properties* → *Details* dialog directly, or with a tool like Adobe Bridge / digiKam that writes XMP. Magpie will pick that tag up the next time you re-add the folder to import fresh.

Files are missing from the grid

What happens: A folder has 500 files in File Explorer but only 480 appear in Magpie.

Common reasons:

- **Unusual file formats.** Magpie handles the ones listed on [Supported file formats](#). Others are skipped.
 - **Hidden files.** Files marked as Hidden or System in Windows are skipped on purpose.
 - **A previous scan hit an error.** Right-click the folder → **Rescan folder** to try again.
-

The folder shows “(offline)” in the sidebar

What happens: A folder that used to work now appears greyed-out with an *(offline)* label.

Why: Magpie couldn't reach the folder on disk. Usually this is because the drive is unplugged (external disk) or a network share is not reachable right now.

Fix: Plug the drive back in / reconnect to the network share. Click **Rescan** at the top of the window. The folder should come back online.

The app is slow / the grid stutters

What to try:

- **Wait for the first scan.** The very first time Magpie reads a folder it works your CPU hard making thumbnails. Give it a few minutes. Next time you open the app, it'll be instant.
- **Close other heavy apps.** Magpie uses your graphics card to draw the grid smoothly. If another app is eating that up, both apps suffer.

- **Restart Magpie.** Sometimes the simplest fix.
-

“Save failed” message

What happens: After adding a tag or title, a red **Save failed** message appears in the details panel.

Fix: Most common causes:

1. **Disk full.** The project file is tiny but SQLite needs a few kilobytes free to write.
2. **Project file is on a drive that’s read-only right now.** If the `.magpie` file lives on an unplugged external drive or a network share that’s unreachable, saves will fail. Reconnect and retry.
3. **Another Magpie window has the same project open.** Close the other instance and try again — only one Magpie can safely write to the same project at a time.

The log file (see below) will tell you exactly what went wrong.

Rename failed

What happens: You edit a filename, press Enter, and it snaps back with a red error underneath.

Common reasons:

- **A file with that name already exists** in the same folder.
- **The name contains characters Windows won’t accept:** `\ / : * ? " < > | .`
- **The file is locked** by another program (Photoshop, a preview, Explorer’s own preview pane). Close the other app and try again.

Just made a rename you regret? **Edit** → **Undo** (Ctrl + Z) puts the old name back.

Resetting Magpie

If Magpie gets into a weird state and you want to start fresh:

- **Just this project?** Close it (Project → Close Project), then either delete the `.magpie` file or move it aside, then create a new one. Any tags you'd added inside that project are gone.
- **Preferences too (theme, font size, recent projects)?** Close Magpie. Open File Explorer, paste `%APPDATA%\com.magpie.app` into the address bar, and delete `app-settings.json`. Your project files themselves stay wherever you saved them.
- **Everything, including thumbnails and logs?** Delete the whole `%APPDATA%\com.magpie.app` folder. Your project files stay put.

Tip: back up your `.magpie` file(s) somewhere safe first. That single file per project is your whole library backup.

Finding the log file

Magpie keeps a diary of everything it does at:

```
%APPDATA%\com.magpie.app\logs\app.log
```

Open it in Notepad. The bottom of the file is the most recent activity. Lines beginning with `WARN` or `ERROR` are the interesting ones if something went wrong. This is the file to share (or paste into) if you ever report a bug.